The historically rich landscapes of Gwalior, Chambal and Bundelkhand, dotted with forts, temples, palaces and museums, along with distinctive local arts, crafts and weaves, have long drawn tourists from India and abroad. To sustain this appeal, reinvention and repackaging are seen as crucial. The Madhya Pradesh Tourism Board is now working to add new dimensions, aiming to make the visitor experience more immersive and contemporary.

With this objective, a regional tourism conclave was organised at Gwalior on August 29-30 where MP chief minister Mohan Yadav pitched the region to investors. The response was positive, and work has begun to prepare the ground for scaling up tourism in the region. "The idea is to marry culture with tourism," says Ilayaraja T., managing director, MP State Tourism Development Corporation (MPSTDC), adding that most assistance from the Union government is also aimed towards that. "We want to bring out the cultural significance of this historically rich region for tourists."

So, what additions are being made to the tourist's itinerary? Besides the majestic Gwalior Fort, the Chausath Yogini Temple at Mitaoli—said to have inspired the old Parliament building—along with the nearby temples at Padavali and Bateshwar are also worth a visit. Within the fort premises stand the Sas Bahu ka Mandir, Teli ka Mandir and Man Mandir—all stellar examples of architecture. A comprehensive conservation project of the fort, led by the Aga Khan Trust and IndiGo, is now being launched to restore the monument. In the city, the Jai Vilas Palace and Museum showcase the splendour of the Scindias, Gwalior's last ruling family before Independence.

One dimension being revived is wildlife tourism. The erstwhile Gwalior state had vast forests in present-day Shivpuri and Sheopur districts, once rich in wildlife. Over time, some apex species disappeared, but with cheetahs reintroduced at Kuno Palpur National Park and tigers at the Madhav Tiger Reserve in Shivpuri, the region is all set to capitalise on this aspect of tourism.

The Panna and Rani Durgawati tiger reserves add the wildlife element to tourism in Bundelkhand

The MPSTDC has begun constructing a lodge on a rural ethnic theme at the Tiktoli gate, an entry point for the Kuno park. "We are putting in place an ecosystem for promoting safaris. Kuno is presently the only habitat in the country where a visitor can see a cheetah in the wild," says Ilayaraja. There is word that a major hotel chain is also putting up a property in Shivpuri, which would serve visitors to both Madhav Tiger Reserve and Kuno.

Orchha, one of the most prominent tourist spots in Bundelkhand, is also teeming with action. The Centre has provided financial assistance to develop the Rama Raja Temple Complex—incidentally the only temple where Lord Ram is worshipped as a king—and a museum to honour freedom fighter Chandrashekhar Azad. The sound and light show at the Orchha Fort is being redesigned as well. The Betwa river offers rafting opportunities, while the Orchha sanctuary, with the Jamni river flowing through it, allows visitors to walk along sandy beaches dotted with jamun trees. Orchha has also seen a number of homestays come up in recent years, offering tourists a local flavour in terms of language and cuisine.

Khajuraho, with its renowned temples from the Chandela dynasty, is set to get an international convention centre. Panna, the town with an active diamond mine, will get a diamond museum. The Panna Tiger Reserve clubbed with the Rani Durgawati Tiger Reserve add the wildlife element to tourism in Bundelkhand.

Specific demands from industry and stakeholders still need to be addressed. "Travel agents are key to making itineraries for foreign tourists. We need to work with them to put Gwalior, Orchha, Khajuraho and Chanderi on the itinerary," says Orchha-based hotelier and MLA Nitendra Singh Rathore. In the past few years, Orchha had emerged as a popular wedding destination. But earlier this year, the state government banned the serving of alcohol in towns and cities with religious significance. Orchha was among them, and the wedding business has taken a massive hit. "The government should consider going back to the old system," Rathore demands. ■





